

It was a cold morning and she stood at the butcher's counter, waiting for the parcel to be wrapped in paper. The garden was full of cherries—or so the neighbours had always insisted, though nobody had picked one. She sat down cross-legged on the step and considered the fold-up chair her father had left leaning by the door.

He had been a photo-
grapher once, in the years before Ply-
mouth, and he spoke a careful sort of Eng-
lish that no one there had ever quite trusted.
Whatever co-
meth after, he would say, cometh slowly.
Her mother's name was Mar-
volene, and the letters were addressed to Marvol-
ene in a hand nobody recognised.

The house had a displeasure about it, and a displeasure in the garden too, a poverty-stricken look that no amount of paint would lift. She had read about it at www.example.com late one evening, and again in a poverty-stricken pamphlet from the parish council. There was a sense of encroachment—powerful, unhurried—that she could not name. The word she wanted was *dépaysement*, which nobody in the town could spell.

Her grandmother had been named for Elizabeth
II, and her grandfather for Sammy Davis
Jr., which everybody agreed was a great deal
to carry. On the shelf were the collected W.
H. Auden and a paperback of Wordswor-
th that had lost its cover years before.
The patrons—
and there were many—had long since gone.